So why did Rahul not bite the bullet? Some Congress leaders claim that the idea of Rahul visiting Anna Hazare at Ramlila Maidan was fraught with risk. ‘The atmosphere there was anti-Congress.

What if the crowd had turned hostile?’ Another senior leader claims that Team Anna could not be trusted to keep their word. ‘They had betrayed us on more than one occasion. How could we risk sending Rahul to Ram Lila Maidan with no guarantee of a final solution?’ In the end, former Maharashtra chief minister Vilasrao Deshmukh was sent to end Anna’s fast. Rahul stayed at home.

Rahul did speak in support of the Lok Pal in a Parliament debate on 26 August, calling for the entity to be given constitutional status similar to that of the Election Commission. ‘Madam Speaker, why not elevate the debate and fortify the Lok Pal by making it a constitutional body accountable to Parliament like the Election Commission? I feel the time has come to seriously consider this idea,’ he said. The Congress cheered, even called Rahul’s ‘idea’ a ‘game changer’. The reality was that the game had already changed. Rahul’s brief intervention in a Parliament debate was lost in the din over corruption. At a time when the country was looking for visible and concrete action, Rahul was giving a sermon. Where he could have seized the moment, he was reduced to a bit player. Anna Hazare and his team, especially a short young man with a toothbrush moustache, had become the real stars of the show. Rahul’s loss would be the gain of a certain Mr Arvind Kejriwal.

The Lok Pal Bill was finally passed in Parliament on 17 December 2013, just months ahead of the general elections. Congressmen cheered yet again, giving the credit to Rahul’s commitment to weeding out corruption. No one really bought the claim. It was simply a case of too little, too late.

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In December 2012, Rahul had another opportunity to position himself as a politician connected to the anxieties and aspirations of a young India. On 16 December, a young woman was brutally beaten and gang-raped on a